PMBOK / PMI | PMB-01

Project Charter

The document that formally authorises the project and the project manager

Meridian Group

Programme Helios — Infrastructure and Platform Stack for AI GPU Compute at Scale

Field	Detail
Document title	Project Charter
Document reference	*PMB-01-HEL-T2-v1.0*
Project / Programme	*Helios Tranche 2 — Scale Build*
Version	*1.0*
Status	*Baselined*
Date	*18 Sep 2026*
Author	*D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager*
Owner	*Project sponsor issues it; project manager drafts it*
Approver	*Project sponsor or initiating authority*
Classification	*Internal*
Retention	*7 years from programme closure*

Document control

Version history

Version	Date	Author	Summary of change
0.1	*04 Jun 2026*	*D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager*	*Initial draft*
0.2	*21 Jul 2026*	*D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager*	*Updated following workstream lead review*
1.0	*18 Sep 2026*	*D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager*	*Baselined at the Tranche 2 funding gate*

Reviewers

Name	Role	Review scope	Date reviewed
T. Nakamura, Chief Platform Architect	*Chief Platform Architect*	*Technical content and solution alignment*	*08 Sep 2026*
L. Haddad, CISO	*CISO*	*Security, assurance and residency content*	*10 Sep 2026*
C. Whitfield, Finance Business Partner	*Finance Business Partner*	*Cost, funding and benefit figures*	*11 Sep 2026*
M. Verity, Head of P3O	*Head of P3O*	*Governance standards and completeness*	*15 Sep 2026*

Approval

This product is baselined once approval is recorded below. Any subsequent change must go through change control.

Name	Role	Decision	Date
R. Al Mazrouei, Group CTO	*Senior Responsible Owner / Group CTO*	*Approved*	*18 Sep 2026*
H. Farrell, Director of Infrastructure	*Director of Infrastructure*	*Approved*	*18 Sep 2026*
L. Haddad, CISO	*CISO*	*Approved subject to closure of ISS-003*	*18 Sep 2026*

Related products

Reference	Product	Relationship
PMB-06	Project Management Plan	Elaborates how the charter will be delivered
PMB-04	Stakeholder Register	Initial version created alongside the charter
PMB-02	Assumption Log	Started here
P2-02	Project Brief	PRINCE2 equivalent

How to use this template

Aspect	Guidance
Purpose	Formally authorises the existence of the project, appoints the project manager and states their authority level, and records the high-level requirements, objectives, risks, budget and stakeholders at authorisation.
Framework	PMBOK / PMI — Integration Management — Develop Project Charter (Initiating)
Created when	At project initiation, before planning begins
Reviewed / updated	Rarely changed; reissued only if the project purpose or authority changes materially
Owner	Project sponsor issues it; project manager drafts it
Approver	Project sponsor or initiating authority
Format options	Document, presentation, register entry, or tool record — the content matters, not the medium.
Tailoring	The charter is short — two to five pages. Detail belongs in the project management plan. The essential elements are the authorisation, the project manager's authority, and the success criteria.

This is a worked example. Every field has been completed with illustrative content for Programme Helios, a fictional AI GPU infrastructure and platform programme. All example content is shown in grey italic — the black text is the template itself. Replace the grey italic content with your own.

Quality criteria

Use these to check the product is fit for purpose before submitting it for approval.

- It is issued by someone external to the project with authority to commit funding
- The project manager is named and their authority limits are explicit
- Success criteria are measurable and stated by the sponsor, not inferred
- High-level requirements are stated as needs, not solutions
- Assumptions and constraints known at authorisation are recorded

Contents

1. Project identity

Field	Detail
Project name	*Helios Tranche 2 — Scale Build*
Project ID	*PMB-01-HEL-T2-v1.0*
Sponsor	*R. Al Mazrouei, Group CTO*
Project manager	*D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager*
Business unit	*Group Technology — Infrastructure and Platform*
Date authorised	*18 Sep 2026*
Target start	*01 Sep 2026*
Target completion	*30 Jul 2027*

2. Purpose and justification

The business need and why this project is the response to it.

Three drivers make this urgent. Utilisation across the current siloed estates is unsustainably low. Public cloud rental costs are growing at roughly 40% year on year with no corresponding increase in delivered value. And an increasing proportion of training data is subject to UAE residency obligations that the current arrangement cannot satisfy without exception.

3. Measurable project objectives and success criteria

What the project must achieve for the sponsor to consider it successful. Every objective needs a measure.

Ref	Objective	Success criterion	Measure	Target
OBJ-01	*Three tenants can run concurrently on hall A with fair-share quota enforced under contention*	*Quota holds within 5% for each tenant across a 72-hour contention test*	*Environment request-to-usable time*	*Under 2 hours*
OBJ-02	*Low-priority training jobs can be pre-empted and resumed without loss of work*	*A pre-empted 64-GPU job resumes from checkpoint with no data loss*	*GPU utilisation, rolling 30-day average*	*AED 5.1m per year*
OBJ-03	*Only signed container images from the internal registry can run on the estate*	*Unsigned image admission refused and alerted within 30 seconds*	*Rolling 12-month PUE*	*3 days median*
OBJ-04	*Nodes failing firmware attestation are quarantined automatically at admission*	*A node with modified firmware is refused and quarantined without human action*	*All-reduce efficiency at 256-GPU scale*	*72% by Q4 2027*
OBJ-05	*Each tenant receives a monthly consumption statement that reconciles*	*Statement reconciles to raw telemetry within 2% for three consecutive months*	*Open critical security findings*	*1.21 PUE*

Ref	Objective	Success criterion	Measure	Target
	to telemetry			
OBJ-06	*GPU telemetry is available at 10-second resolution with 13-month retention*	*Telemetry present at stated resolution and retention verified by sampling*	*Median training cycle time*	*92% at 256-GPU job scale*

4. High-level requirements

Needs, not designs. Detail is elaborated later in requirements documentation.

Ref	Requirement	Source	Priority
REQ-001	*The platform shall provide scheduled access to GPU capacity for at least three tenants with enforced fair-share quotas*	*Business case*	*M*
REQ-002	*The platform shall support both interactive notebook workloads and long-running distributed training jobs*	*AI Research*	*M*
REQ-003	*Training data classified as Restricted shall not leave UAE territory at rest or in transit*	*Group data residency policy v4.2*	*M*
REQ-004	*All container images shall be signed and admitted only from the approved internal registry*	*Group security standard*	*M*
REQ-005	*The fabric shall sustain at least 92% all-reduce efficiency at 256-GPU job scale*	*Architecture design*	*M*
REQ-006	*The storage tier shall sustain 1.2 TB/s aggregate read throughput to the compute estate*	*Architecture design*	*M*
REQ-007	*Users shall be able to self-serve a working training environment within two hours of request*	*Business case*	*S*

5. High-level project description and boundaries

In scope	Out of scope
DXB-1 halls A and B, 2,048 accelerators and the supporting fabric and storage	*Facilities, power and cooling works within the Tranche 2 boundary*
The three onboarding tenants and their committed migration workloads	*DXB-1 halls A and B, 2,048 accelerators and the supporting fabric and storage*
Excludes AUH-2, model development and business-unit data engineering	*Facilities, power and cooling works within the Tranche 2 boundary*
Excludes AUH-2, model development and business-unit data engineering	*DXB-1 halls A and B, 2,048 accelerators and the supporting fabric and storage*

6. Deliverables

Ref	Deliverable	Description	Accepted by
D-01	*Operations runbook set with two completed live drills*	*Service operations readiness for liquid-cooled infrastructure, including leak response*	*D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager*
D-02	*Platform v1.0 — scheduling, quota, observability and image supply chain*	*400G RoCEv2 leaf-spine fabric tuned for collective communication at 256-GPU job scale*	*K. Adeyemi, Security Architect*
D-03	*Operations runbook set with two completed live drills*	*Signed container image supply chain with admission enforcement and firmware attestation*	*I. Petrova, Data Platform Lead*
D-04	*Platform v1.0 — scheduling, quota, observability and image supply chain*	*Parallel filesystem tier of 12 PB usable sustaining 1.2 TB/s to the compute estate*	*J. Ferreira, Network Lead*

7. Overall project risk

The high-level risks known at authorisation, and the sponsor's risk appetite.

Ref	Risk	Potential impact	Initial response
RSK-001	*Because GPU allocation is constrained by vendor quota, the Tranche 2 hardware delivery may slip beyond November 2026, causing the platform build to start late and the AI enablement benefit to be deferred by a quarter*	*5*	*Allocation confirmed in writing at contract award; 20% of Tranche 2 volume dual-sourced; staged acceptance so hall A can proceed independently of hall B*
RSK-002	*Because DXB-1 hall B was designed for 8 kW racks, the 60 kW liquid-cooled racks may exceed the available floor loading and chilled water capacity, causing a redesign mid-build*	*5*	*Structural survey completed before hall B order; CDU capacity modelled at N+1; contingency for a reduced 1,536-GPU configuration held*
RSK-003	*Because the platform will host model weights and training data from three business units, weak tenant isolation may allow cross-tenant data access, causing a reportable data incident and loss of regulatory standing*	*5*	*Namespace and network policy isolation validated by penetration test before multi-tenant go-live; per-tenant KMS keys; quarterly control testing*
RSK-004	*Because the platform engineering skill set is scarce in-market, recruitment of the six planned SRE roles may take longer than three months, causing the MLOps workstream to depend on contractors beyond Tranche 2*	*3*	*Two contractors engaged from October 2026 with knowledge-transfer clauses; internal conversion programme from the infrastructure team*

Ref	Risk	Potential impact	Initial response
RSK-005	*Because the 400G RoCEv2 fabric is new to the organisation, congestion control tuning may not achieve the target 92% collective communication efficiency, causing training job throughput to fall short of the business case*	*4*	*NCCL benchmark gate at pilot exit; vendor performance engineering engaged for two weeks per hall; fallback to reduced job scale documented*

8. Summary milestone schedule

Milestone	Target date	Significance
Programme mandate approved and funding released for Tranche 1	*12 Mar 2026*	*Gate*
Pilot cluster of 256 GPUs live in DXB-1 hall A	*28 Aug 2026*	*Delivery*
Tranche 1 end-of-tranche review and Tranche 2 funding gate	*18 Sep 2026*	*Gate*
Hall B structural strengthening complete	*15 Dec 2026*	*Delivery*
Utility uplift to 6 MVA energised	*30 Nov 2026*	*External*
Hall A scaled to 1,024 GPUs and accepted	*26 Feb 2027*	*Delivery*

9. Preapproved financial resources

Category	Amount	Funding source	Conditions
Accelerator hardware	*AED 91,200,000*	*Solution intent wiki, DXB-1 platform space*	*Funded from the Tranche 2 allocation of AED 118,000,000*
Storage and parallel filesystem	*AED 17,800,000*	*ALM tool — Helios ART board*	*Applies from hall A handover; hall B follows in Tranche 2 closure*
Network fabric	*AED 13,600,000*	*Assurance evidence pack, Tranche 2 gate*	*Applies across DXB-1 halls A and B for the Tranche 2 scale build*
Facilities — power, cooling, structural	*AED 24,300,000*	*Configuration management database*	*Escalated to the Portfolio Board where it exceeds programme tolerance*
Platform software and licences	*AED 6,800,000*	*Programme SharePoint — Helios / Tranche 2 / Governance*	*Carried forward from the Tranche 1 lessons register*

10. Key stakeholders

Stakeholder	Role	Interest	Influence
R. Al Mazrouei, Group CTO	*Group CTO*	*Delivery of AI compute capability within the approved envelope*	*H*
L. Haddad, CISO	*CISO*	*Tenant isolation, supply chain integrity and data residency*	*H*
A. Rahimi, CFO	*Group CFO*	*Capital efficiency and the credibility of the benefit case*	*H*
Dr S. Iyer, Head of AI Research	*Business unit head*	*Priority access and low-friction environments*	*M*
M. Duarte, Head of Fraud Analytics	*Business unit head*	*Retaining control of a departmental cluster being decommissioned*	*M*
G. Lindqvist, Service Operations Lead	*Service Operations Lead*	*Supportability of liquid-cooled infrastructure*	*M*

11. Project approval requirements

What constitutes success, who decides it, and who signs off the project as complete.

Programme Helios — Tranche 2 scale build, DXB-1 halls A and B. Maintained by the P3O as part of the assurance evidence library. Detail is maintained by the Project sponsor issues it; project manager drafts it and reviewed at the monthly Programme Board.

12. Project exit criteria

The conditions under which the project would be closed or terminated early.

Programme Helios — Tranche 2 scale build, DXB-1 halls A and B. Confirmed at the Tranche 1 end-of-tranche review, 18 Sep 2026. Detail is maintained by the Project sponsor issues it; project manager drafts it and reviewed at the monthly Programme Board.

13. Project manager authority

Be specific. Vague authority is the single commonest cause of delay in a matrix organisation.

Area	Authority level	Escalation threshold
Staffing	*D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager*	*To the Programme Manager within one working day; to the SRO within three*
Budget	*D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager*	*To the Programme Manager within one working day; to the SRO within three*
Technical decisions	*D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager*	*To the Programme Manager within one working day; to the SRO within three*

Area	Authority level	Escalation threshold
Conflict resolution	*Direct discussion first, then facilitated by the Programme Manager, then decided by the SRO*	*Helios Tranche 2 — Scale Build*
Contracts and procurement	*D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager*	*To the Programme Manager within one working day; to the SRO within three*
Schedule changes	*Tranche 2 completes 30 Jul 2027; tolerance of +4 weeks at programme level*	*To the Programme Manager within one working day; to the SRO within three*

14. Assumptions and constraints

Ref	Type	Description	Impact if invalid
ASM-001	Assumption / Constraint	*Vendor GPU allocation of 2,048 units for Tranche 2 will be honoured at the quoted delivery dates*	*Tranche 2 completion slips by at least one quarter and contract terms are renegotiated*
ASM-002	*Assumption*	*DXB-1 has 6 MVA of usable capacity available to the programme without a utility upgrade*	*Tranche 2 capped at 1,024 GPUs and the AUH-2 site is brought forward two quarters*
ASM-003	*Assumption*	*Three business units will migrate committed workloads within six months of hall A handover*	*Utilisation benefit of AED 14.2m over five years is not realised in full*
ASM-004	*Constraint*	*Training data classified as Restricted must remain within UAE borders at rest and in transit*	*Not applicable — this is a fixed constraint on design*
ASM-005	*Assumption*	*Liquid cooling maintenance can be absorbed by the existing facilities contract without an uplift*	*Annual run cost increases by approximately AED 780,000*
ASM-006	*Constraint*	*No production change may be made during the Group financial close window, the last five working days of each quarter*	*Not applicable — planned into the release calendar*
ASM-007	*Assumption*	*The existing 400G core has spare port capacity for four additional leaf pairs*	*Additional AED 2.1m of core switching required and eight weeks of lead time added*